

Why Governments Should Adopt Open Source

How applicable is the open source software development model for e-governance initiatives?

Discourses on open source and free software generally approach the subject as a philosophy. There are a significant number of articles and papers that discuss free and open source software from the perspectives and interpretation offered by political economy and social commons. A suitably detailed perspective of open source was provided in *The Cathedral and the Bazaar* by Eric S Raymond. Since then, there have been sporadic attempts to reconcile the principles of open source with established practices in software development.

However, in recent times, there has been a renewed trend to strip away the theoretical bulwarks of the open source and Free Software movements and focus on the deliverables. Reinterpreting a few of those concepts, we would like to discuss the relevance of open source as a 'software development model' and its applicability to e-governance initiatives.

Open source is, primarily, a software development methodology. As is the norm with any other methodology or practice, open source has its unique ethos, rituals and codes. Hence, there is an established philosophy around it. Leaving the philosophy aside, the important aspects of open source as a software development method are:

- Collaborate to develop code
- Reuse innovation
- Release early, release often

We will use the above three aspects and derive the related ethos of open source and, in conclusion, will demonstrate the suitability of this model as applicable to ICT4D application development.

Open source mandates a level of intense collaboration. Such engagement between developers and users leads to an improvement in the quality of the code. Feature enhancements and the identification and resolution of defects occur seamlessly because the source code is available for